

Semantic page structure

Module 1 - Lesson 1

Overview

Semantic HTML gives every part of a web page a meaningful role instead of a generic `<div>`. Search engines, screen readers, and other developers all benefit when the structure of a document matches its actual content.

Key Concepts

- Semantic tags such as `<header>`, `<nav>`, `<main>`, `<article>`, `<section>`, `<aside>`, and `<footer>` describe the purpose of each region of the page.
- A document should have exactly one `<main>` element containing the primary content of the page.
- `<article>` is for self-contained content that could be republished on its own; `<section>` groups related content under a common theme.
- Use heading levels `<h1>` through `<h6>` as an outline, with a single `<h1>` per page and no skipped levels.
- Landmark regions let assistive technology jump directly to navigation, search, main content, or complementary information.
- Semantic HTML is the foundation of accessibility and SEO: the DOM carries meaning that CSS classes alone cannot express.

Example

```
<header>
  <h1>My Course</h1>
  <nav aria-label="Main"><a href="/">Home</a></nav>
</header>
<main>
  <article>
    <h2>Lesson one</h2>
    <p>Meaningful structure beats div soup.</p>
  </article>
</main>
<footer>Copyright 2026</footer>
```

Summary

Semantic elements communicate the structure and meaning of your page to browsers, search engines, and screen readers. Build the outline with headings, use landmarks for navigation and content, and reserve `<div>` for styling-only containers.

Practice Checklist

- Convert a page built with nested `<div>` elements into semantic landmarks.
- Add a single `<h1>` and a logical heading outline to a sample page.
- Run a Lighthouse accessibility audit and confirm landmark structure is recognized.